LXVII

SOME RECENT HAPPENINGS

Dawn reddens in the wake of night, but the days of our life return not.
The eye contains a far horizon, but the wound of spring lies deep in the heart.

Li Tài-Po.

I FOLLOWED from the newspapers supplied to me the proceedings of the Bombay session of the Congress. I was naturally interested in its politics and personalities. Twenty years' intimate association had tied me up so closely with it that my individuality had almost become merged in it, and far stronger than the claims of office and responsibility were the invisible bonds that tied me to that great organisation and to thousands of my old comrades. And yet I felt it difficult to get excited over its proceedings; in spite of some important decisions the whole session seemed to me a dull affair. The subjects that interested me were hardly discussed. What would I have done if I had been there, I wondered. I did not know for certain; I could not say how I would have reacted to the new conditions and my surroundings. And I saw no reason why I should force my mind to come to a difficult decision in prison when such a decision was wholly unnecessary then. The time would come when I would have to face the problems of the day and decide on my course of action. It was needless folly to anticipate that decision, even in the recesses of my mind, for circumstances would change before that choice was forced on me.

The two outstanding features of the Congress, as far as I could make out from my distant and secluded abode on the mountains, were: the dominant personality of Gandhiji and the exceedingly poor show that the communal opposition under Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya and Mr. Aney put up. To all who have knowledge of the inner workings of the Indian mass-mind, as well as the middle-class mind, it was no surprise to find that Gandhiji continues to be far and away *the* master figure in India. Government officials and some secluded politicians often imagine, making the wish the father to the thought, that he is played out in the political field or, at least, that his influence has greatly declined. And then when he